

Nagarjuna Akkineni

BRAHMASTRA

The veteran Telugu star returns to Hindi cinema after nearly two decades as an artist with superpowers in this fantasy action series featuring Ranbir Kapoor, Alia Bhatt and Amitabh Bachchan
Release: September 9

Prabhas

ADIPURUSH, SALAAR & PROJECT K

Mr Bahubali has three big pan-India films in the pipeline. The Telugu superstar starts off with *Adipurush*, which is based on the epic Ramayana





"Telugu filmmakers didn't leave the commercial film. You have to give songs, fights, romance, laughs and heroism. It's like a garland made of different flowers. It keeps us connected to all of India"

—SUKUMAR
Writer-director, Pushpa: The Rise – Chapter I

became the first Kannada film to pull off a pan-India release. Yash had a heroic role to play in showcasing the merits of the Kannada film industry.

HIGH ON STYLE

One of the biggest film distributors in the business, Anil Thadani remembers watching an edit of the first chapter of *KGF* without subtitles and Yash by his side translating the lines every five minutes. Thadani, who distributed the Bahubali films and *Pushpa*, says, "For me, Yash was a star, he had his own style." And style has been quintessential in making gods out of men in the South, a phenomenon alien to the Hindi film industry. Temples are built, mammoth installations put up during releases and, during Yash's birthday celebrations in January 2020, even a 5,000 kg cake devoured in Bengaluru. But the adulation remained limited to the states, Rajinikanth being the only exception.

The Hindi film audience, feels Shailesh Kapoor, CEO of Ormax Media, a company that tracks film trends, box office data and media consumption patterns, is hooked to this 'style'. "There's machismo linked to it. It is not your typical build-your-abs and rip-off-the-shirt masculinity," he adds. "It is more in the personality of the character than the physique." In Bollywood of late, by contrast, masculinity equals flaunting a muscular body. No wonder Hindi actors have struggled to make a breakthrough in the southern market where larger-than-life spectacles are more routine compared to Hindi cinema. "When we make a commercial film, they have already seen something that's bigger in terms of scale and action," says Thadani. "The expense is much more. In the South, they pay the actors and also have the guts to spend on the film."

Thadani attributes it to Hindi filmmakers "mak-